The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

China criticised America for “unjustly suppressing foreign companies” after the House of Representatives approved a bill that could ban **TikTok** in the country. Shou Chew, TikTok’s boss, urged the social-media platform’s **American** users to “protect” their “constitutional rights”. Should the Senate also pass the bipartisan legislation, Bytedance, TikTok’s Chinese owner, would be forced to sell the app to an owner of another nationality or face a ban in its largest market. Regulators worry that China is using the app to gather Americans’ personal data.

Israel’s army said it wanted to “flood” Gaza with aid via new land routes into the besieged enclave. One such route opened on Tuesday, enabling the first delivery of food into northern Gaza in three weeks. Aid agencies warn that Gazans are on the brink of famine. The EU’s foreign-policy chief says Israel is using starvation as a weapon of war.

Janet Yellen, **America’s** treasury secretary, said that interest rates were “unlikely” to return to the low levels seen before the pandemic. The yield on ten-year US Treasury notes averaged 2.4% between 2010 and 2020, but reached 5% last October after the Federal Reserve raised rates to combat inflation. It is now at 4.2%.

Geert Wilders, whose anti-immigrant Freedom Party won the most votes in the **Dutch** election in November, appeared to take himself out of the running for prime minister. Mr Wilders said he was throwing in the towel because he was unable to secure support from other parties. He said he wants the Netherlands to have a “right-wing cabinet”; one in which he will presumably play a prominent role.

Denmark announced it would extend military conscription to women from 2026, and increase the expected service time from four to 11 months. It will also raise military spending from 1.4% of GDP to 2% in order to meet the target set by NATO. Denmark has been one of Ukraine's staunchest allies.

OpenAI, an American artificial-intelligence startup, announced partnerships with *Le Monde*, a French newspaper, and Prisa Media, a Spanish conglomerate. Users of **ChatGPT**, OpenAI's human-sounding chatbot, will be able to summarise news content from the publishers in the coming months. Financial details were not disclosed.

A high court in **Japan** ruled that the country's ban on **gay marriage** violated the constitution. The case is now likely to proceed to the Supreme Court. More than two-thirds of Japan's population think same-sex marriage should be legal. But the ruling Liberal Democratic Party opposes it.

Figure of the day: 40%, the share of China's GDP growth created by clean-energy industries last year. Read the full story.

In the run-up to America's presidential election, we've launched The US in brief—a daily update to help you keep on top of the political stories that matter. Sign up here to receive it as a newsletter, each weekday, in your inbox.

Photo: Reuters

NATO’s secretary-general steps down

After ten years in the job Jens Stoltenberg, NATO’s secretary-general, will deliver his final annual report on Thursday. He leaves the military alliance in good shape. But it is facing great challenges. Because of Vladimir Putin’s aggression against Ukraine, NATO has rediscovered its role as the bastion of European territorial defence against Russia.

Last week, Sweden joined Finland as a new NATO member. Both countries bring sophisticated military capabilities to defending NATO’s border in the Baltics and in the high north. Roughly two-thirds of NATO’s 32 members are on track this year to reach or exceed the target of spending 2% of GDP on defence. And the alliance is currently conducting its biggest exercise since the cold war, involving 90,000 troops.

But the failure to deliver sufficient munitions to Ukraine has allowed Russia, for now, to take the advantage in the war. Perhaps most worrying is the possibility of NATO-hating Donald Trump returning to the White House and effectively taking America out of the alliance.

Photo: Alamy

Foxconn’s next chapter

Foxconn, one of the largest electronics manufacturers in the world, is often regarded as a gauge of economic activity in China, where its largest factories are located. Some analysts also look to its production lines for a sense of how Apple, the American technology giant, is performing. Foxconn’s factories churn out more iPhones than any other company’s. But the Taiwanese group, which just celebrated its 50th anniversary, is trying to shift what it makes and where it makes it.

Analysts therefore watched Foxconn’s fourth-quarter results, released on Thursday, closely. They were looking for a sense of the company’s direction as it moves beyond making phones in China. The signs were good: Foxconn announced profits of $1.6bn between October and December, marking its second consecutive quarter of growth. This suggests that the group’s recent moves—including investing in America and India, and producing more electric vehicles—are paying off. But those changes will, in turn, change how the company copes with the complicated politics of Taiwanese-Chinese-American relations.

Photo: Getty Images

Spain votes on an amnesty for Catalan separatists

On Thursday the lower house of Spain's parliament will vote on an amnesty for hundreds of people involved in an illegal referendum in 2017 held in a failed push for Catalan independence.

The issue has consumed Spanish politics since last summer. Pedro Sánchez, the prime minister, fell short of a majority in an election in July. To secure the votes of Catalan separatists in parliament he

proposed an amnesty—an idea he had previously called unconstitutional. The political right, and many of Mr Sánchez's fellow Socialists, are outraged by the volte-face. Parliament rejected a previous version of the deal in January. The Catalan separatist leaders who stand to benefit have neither apologised for their actions nor promised not to try again. But Mr Sánchez exercises tight control over his party and has now secured the votes he needs from other parties.

An amnesty would eventually allow Carles Puigdemont—the former president of the regional government of Catalonia, exiled in Belgium since 2017—to return. Whether it would heal wounds is another matter.

Photo: AP

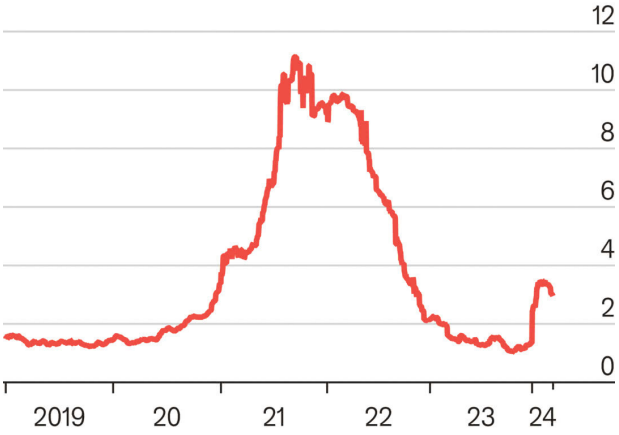
How global shipping is faring

Globalisation's middlemen have had a testing time. Low waters stalled freighters trying to pass through the Panama Canal. Attacks by the Houthis, an Iran-backed Yemeni militia, on ships in the Red Sea shook global trade. The IMF reports that volumes shipped via the Suez Canal—which normally serves around 15% of maritime trade—fell by half in January and February compared with a year earlier. Most have been redirected around southern Africa.

But DP World's full year results for 2023, released on Thursday, gave an early indication that global trade is holding up—for now. The state-owned Emirati firm, which operates ports in roughly 40 countries, reported that its revenues increased by 6.6% year on year but that profits fell because of higher costs. In January its boss, Sultan Ahmed bin Sulayem, seemed unconcerned about the Houthis' attacks. "I don't see this going on long term," he said. Two months later the Red Sea shows no sign of returning to normal. Commenting on his company's earnings, Mr bin Sulayem offered a more pragmatic view of the "deteriorating geopolitical landscape". Commerce is adapting, but it is a struggle.

Dear straits

Global container-freight costs, $'000
Per 40-foot container



Sources: Freightos Baltic Index; LSEG Workspace

Photo: Dave Simonds

Why golfers are feeling flush

Since the launch of the Saudi-funded LIV Tour two years ago, men's golf has been soaked in money. LIV offered enormous salaries to some of the world's best players to persuade them to defect from America's prestigious PGA Tour. Those offers continue to lure them: Tyrrell Hatton, an English player, moved to LIV in January for a reported sum of at least $60m.

The PGA Tour responded by jacking up the prize money at its own events. This year's Players Championship at Sawgrass in Florida, which begins on Thursday, carries a total purse of $25m, making it more lucrative than any of the four majors. The tour also accepted a $3bn investment from Strategic Sports Group, an American consortium, creating a new commercial entity. Crucially, to encourage their loyalty players will get equity stakes in this venture. Golfers are already among the best-paid athletes on the planet. They are about to get richer still.

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each day this week. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and, as important, tell us the connecting theme. Email your responses (and include mention of your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick randomly from those with the right answers and crown three winners on Saturday.

Thursday: The white rose was the symbol of which English royal house?

Wednesday: Louis Philippe, King of France from 1830 to 1848, stemmed from which cadet branch of the Bourbon family?

> *Life would be tragic if it weren't funny.*
>
> *Stephen Hawking*